

Research Methodology in Public Administration

Proposal Writing and Report Writing

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Literature Review

Understanding What is Already Known Before Conducting Research

Research Problem → Literature Review → Research Gap → Research Design

What is a Literature Review?

A **literature review** is a systematic examination and critical analysis of existing knowledge related to a particular research topic or problem.

It may include:

- ▶ Books
- ▶ Journal articles
- ▶ Research reports
- ▶ Theses and dissertations
- ▶ Government publications
- ▶ Policy documents
- ▶ Relevant academic and institutional sources

Why Do We Review Literature?

A literature review helps the researcher to:

1. Understand the existing body of knowledge.
2. Identify gaps in existing research.
3. Avoid unnecessary duplication.
4. Refine the research problem.
5. Develop research questions and objectives.
6. Build a theoretical or conceptual foundation.
7. Select an appropriate research methodology.

Literature Review and Research Process

Broad Area of Interest



Research Topic



Preliminary Literature Review



Research Problem



Detailed Literature Review



Types of Literature

Literature relevant to a research study may include:

Academic Sources

- ▶ Books
- ▶ Journal articles
- ▶ Research papers
- ▶ Theses
- ▶ Dissertations

Other Relevant Sources

- ▶ Government reports
- ▶ Policy documents
- ▶ Institutional publications
- ▶ Conference papers
- ▶ Statistical reports

Primary and Secondary Sources

Primary Sources

Original sources of information or knowledge.

- ▶ Original research articles
- ▶ Official documents
- ▶ Interviews
- ▶ Historical records
- ▶ Original datasets

Secondary Sources

Sources that interpret, summarize, or discuss primary sources.

- ▶ Review articles
- ▶ Textbooks
- ▶ Literature reviews
- ▶ Academic commentaries
- ▶ Summaries of research

Steps in Conducting a Literature Review

1. Define the research topic or problem.
2. Identify key concepts and keywords.
3. Search for relevant literature.
4. Select relevant and credible sources.
5. Read and critically evaluate the literature.
6. Organize the literature.
7. Identify patterns, relationships, and gaps.
8. Synthesize the findings.
9. Write the literature review.

Step 1: Define the Research Focus

Before searching for literature, clearly define:

- ▶ What is the research topic?
- ▶ What is the research problem?
- ▶ What are the major concepts?
- ▶ What is the geographical context?
- ▶ What is the time period?
- ▶ What population or unit of analysis is involved?

Example

Factors influencing citizens' satisfaction with digital public services in Nepal.

Step 2: Identify Keywords

Keywords help the researcher search systematically for relevant literature.

Research Topic

Factors influencing citizens' satisfaction with digital public services in Nepal.

Possible keywords:

- ▶ Digital public services
- ▶ E-government
- ▶ Digital governance
- ▶ Citizen satisfaction
- ▶ Public service delivery
- ▶ Nepal

Step 3: Search for Literature

Relevant literature can be searched through:

- ▶ University libraries
- ▶ Academic journals
- ▶ Online databases
- ▶ Google Scholar
- ▶ Research institutions
- ▶ Government websites
- ▶ International organizations
- ▶ Academic repositories

Selecting Relevant Literature

Not every available source should be included.

Evaluate each source based on:

- ▶ Relevance to the research problem
- ▶ Academic credibility
- ▶ Author or institutional authority
- ▶ Quality of evidence
- ▶ Methodological soundness
- ▶ Currency or timeliness

Critical Reading of Literature

A literature review is not simply a summary.

While reading, ask:

- ▶ What is the main argument?
- ▶ What research question was addressed?
- ▶ What methodology was used?
- ▶ What are the major findings?
- ▶ What are the strengths and limitations?
- ▶ How is the study relevant to my research?

From Summary to Critical Review

Descriptive Summary

"Author A studied digital governance and found that citizens were generally satisfied with online services."

Critical Review

"Although Author A found a positive relationship between digital governance and citizen satisfaction, the study focused only on urban areas. Therefore, the findings may not explain the experience of citizens in rural areas."

Organizing the Literature

Literature can be organized in different ways:

1. **Thematic Approach** – organized by themes or concepts.
2. **Chronological Approach** – organized by time.
3. **Methodological Approach** – organized by research methods.
4. **Theoretical Approach** – organized according to theories.
5. **Conceptual Approach** – organized around major concepts.

Thematic Organization: An Example

Research Topic

Citizen satisfaction with digital public services

Possible themes:

1. Accessibility of digital services
2. Digital literacy
3. Quality of public services
4. Institutional capacity
5. Citizen satisfaction

The literature is organized around ideas, not authors.

Literature Review Matrix

A literature review matrix helps organize information systematically.

Author	Objective	Method	Key Findings
Author A	To examine digital services	Survey	Accessibility affects satisfaction
Author B	To explore citizen experience	Interview	Digital literacy is important
Author C	To assess service quality	Mixed Methods	Service quality influences use

Synthesis of Literature

Synthesis means bringing different studies together to develop an overall understanding.

For example:

- ▶ Several studies identify accessibility as an important factor.
- ▶ Other studies emphasize digital literacy.
- ▶ Some studies focus on institutional capacity.
- ▶ Findings may differ across geographical and social contexts.

Synthesis

What do the studies collectively tell us?

Identifying the Research Gap

A research gap may exist when:

- ▶ A topic has not been adequately studied.
- ▶ Existing studies provide contradictory findings.
- ▶ Previous research used limited methods.
- ▶ A particular geographical context is missing.
- ▶ A specific population has not been studied.
- ▶ Existing research is outdated.

Example: From Literature to Research Gap

Existing Literature

Previous studies have examined digital public service delivery and citizen satisfaction in different countries and urban contexts.

Identified Gap

Limited evidence exists regarding the factors influencing citizens' satisfaction with digital public services in the Nepalese context, particularly outside major urban areas.



Potential Research Problem

Literature Review and Research Framework

The literature review helps the researcher develop:

Theoretical Foundation

- ▶ Relevant theories
- ▶ Major concepts
- ▶ Previous explanations

Conceptual Framework

- ▶ Key variables
- ▶ Relationships
- ▶ Assumptions
- ▶ Expected outcomes

Literature Review and Research Proposal

In a research proposal, the literature review generally helps to:

1. Establish the context of the research.
2. Demonstrate knowledge of previous studies.
3. Identify the research gap.
4. Justify the proposed study.
5. Develop the theoretical or conceptual framework.
6. Support research questions or hypotheses.

Common Mistakes in Literature Review

- ▶ Listing studies without analysis.
- ▶ Summarizing one author after another.
- ▶ Using irrelevant sources.
- ▶ Relying only on old literature.
- ▶ Ignoring contradictory findings.
- ▶ Failing to identify the research gap.
- ▶ Plagiarism and improper citation.

A Good Literature Review Should

A good literature review should be:

- ▶ Relevant
- ▶ Systematic
- ▶ Critical
- ▶ Analytical
- ▶ Well-organized
- ▶ Synthesized
- ▶ Properly referenced
- ▶ Connected to the research problem

Literature Review: Overall Process

Define Research Topic



Identify Keywords



Search for Literature



Select Relevant Sources



Read and Critically Evaluate



Organize and Synthesize



Managing Literature with Zotero

A literature review involves collecting, organizing, reading, annotating, and citing a large number of sources.

What is Zotero?

Zotero is a reference management tool that helps researchers collect, organize, annotate, cite, and manage academic literature.

Zotero can help researchers:

- ▶ Collect research sources
- ▶ Organize references
- ▶ Store PDF files
- ▶ Highlight and annotate documents
- ▶ Take research notes

Why Use Zotero?

Without a reference management system:

- ▶ Sources may be lost.
- ▶ PDF files may become disorganized.
- ▶ Important ideas may be forgotten.
- ▶ Citation information may be incomplete.
- ▶ Writing references can become time-consuming.

Zotero Helps to Create a Research Workflow

Search → Save → Organize → Read → Annotate → Take Notes → Cite

Getting Started with Zotero

A basic Zotero workflow involves:

1. Install Zotero on your computer.
2. Create or sign in to a Zotero account.
3. Install the Zotero browser connector.
4. Create collections for your research.
5. Search for relevant literature.
6. Save references directly to Zotero.

Collecting Literature Using Zotero

Zotero can help collect references from:

- ▶ Google Scholar
- ▶ Journal websites
- ▶ University libraries
- ▶ Online databases
- ▶ Books and book chapters
- ▶ Research reports
- ▶ Government publications
- ▶ Web-based documents

Important Principle

Always check the bibliographic information after importing a reference into Zotero.

Organizing Literature in Zotero

A research project may contain many different types of sources.

One way to organize them is through **Collections**.

Example: Digital Public Service Delivery

- ▶ Digital Governance
- ▶ E-Government
- ▶ Public Service Delivery
- ▶ Citizen Satisfaction
- ▶ Theoretical Literature
- ▶ Nepal Context

Organize literature according to your research themes.

Using Tags to Organize Literature

In addition to collections, Zotero allows researchers to use **tags**.

For example:

Possible Tags

Theory Methodology Nepal Quantitative Qualitative

Tags can help researchers:

- ▶ Group similar studies.
- ▶ Identify important themes.
- ▶ Find relevant literature quickly.
- ▶ Organize studies across different collections.

Reading and Annotating PDF Files

Zotero can also support active reading of PDF documents.

While reading, researchers can:

- ▶ Highlight important text.
- ▶ Add comments or annotations.
- ▶ Identify important arguments.
- ▶ Mark key concepts.
- ▶ Record questions and observations.

Remember

Do not simply read the literature.
Read actively and critically.

What Should You Look for While Reading?

For each important study, try to identify:

1. What is the research problem?
2. What is the objective of the study?
3. What concepts or theories are used?
4. What methodology is applied?
5. What are the major findings?
6. What are the limitations?
7. How is this study relevant to my research?

Note-Taking Using Zotero

Note-taking is an important part of the literature review process.

For each important source, create a structured research note.

Suggested Structure

- ▶ Full reference
- ▶ Research problem
- ▶ Objectives or research questions
- ▶ Theory or key concepts
- ▶ Methodology
- ▶ Major findings
- ▶ Limitations
- ▶ Relevance to my research

Example of a Literature Note

Reference

Author A (2025). Digital Public Service Delivery and Citizen Satisfaction.

- ▶ **Objective:** To examine citizen satisfaction with digital public services.
- ▶ **Method:** Survey research.
- ▶ **Key Finding:** Accessibility and service quality significantly influence citizen satisfaction.
- ▶ **Limitation:** The study focuses only on urban areas.
- ▶ **My Note:** The study is useful for identifying possible factors, but rural areas require further investigation.

From Annotation to Research Notes

A useful workflow is:

Read the Article



Highlight Important Information



Add Annotations



Create a Structured Note



Connect the Study to Your Research

The Importance of Writing Your Own Notes

When taking notes, distinguish between:

What the Author Says

- ▶ Main argument
- ▶ Key findings
- ▶ Important concepts
- ▶ Direct quotations

Your Own Reflection

- ▶ Why is it important?
- ▶ How is it relevant?
- ▶ Do you agree?
- ▶ What are the limitations?

Avoiding a Common Problem in Note-Taking

Do Not Copy Without Identification

When you copy a direct quotation into your notes, clearly mark it as:

Direct Quote

and always record:

- ▶ Author
- ▶ Year
- ▶ Page number

Good Practice

Use your own words when writing summaries and clearly distinguish your ideas from the author's ideas.

Zotero Notes and Literature Synthesis

Individual notes should eventually be connected to develop **themes**.

For example:

Individual Studies

Study A Study B Study C Study D



Common Themes

Accessibility Digital Literacy Service Quality Institutional Capacity



Literature Review

Using Zotero for Citation and References

Zotero can also assist during academic writing.

Researchers can use Zotero to:

- ▶ Insert in-text citations.
- ▶ Change citation styles.
- ▶ Generate bibliographies.
- ▶ Manage references consistently.

Examples of Citation Styles

APA

Chicago

Harvard

MLA

Always verify automatically generated citations.

An Effective Literature Review Workflow

Define Research Problem



Search for Literature



Save Sources in Zotero



Organize Using Collections and Tags



Read and Annotate



Take Structured Notes



Identify Themes and Research Gaps

Key Takeaway: Literature Review and Zotero

A good literature review requires more than searching and reading.



Collect



Organize



Read



Annotate

Key Takeaway

A Literature Review is not simply
a collection of summaries.



It is a systematic and critical examination
of what is already known,
what remains unknown,
and why further research is needed.